

1 A Primer on the Metaphysics of Man

In this chapter, we will explore some of the essentials of philosophical anthropology: the philosophical, or metaphysical, study of mankind.¹ We will do this for two reasons. First of all, although this course is designed primarily to study logic, it is also intended to be the reader's first exposure to some of the terminology and ideas that will become form the basis of their philosophical inquiry: for example, *ens*, *substance*, *accident*, *faculty*, *habitus*, and *operation*. Second, by laying the philosophical bases, it will be much easier to understand the next chapter, in which we discuss what the *object* of a faculty or *habitus* is in general, and explain in detail the object of logic in particular.

1.1 What are metaphysics and anthropology?

Before beginning in earnest, since this is likely the reader's very first exposure to the sciences of metaphysics and philosophical anthropology, a short introduction to what we are talking about is in order.

Metaphysics is the study of anything that exists—of *entities* (in Latin: *entia*), as we will call them—not according to this or that particular aspect, but simply *because they are*. That is, according to Aristotle's famous definition, metaphysics is the study of existing things (*entia*) *qua* being.² We saw above that sciences study their object with the goal not only of understanding its properties, but with the hope of tracing those properties all the way back to their causes. As can be seen, metaphysics is the most general of sciences: no created entity is excluded from it whatsoever. Therefore, unlike other sciences, it seeks the properties that can be attributed to *all* entities without exception,³ and it seeks the causes on which *all* things depend. It should be noted that metaphysics studies *created entities*, and thus God is actually *not* the object of this science. Rather, He is of interest as both the First and Ultimate extrinsic Cause of all entities:⁴ the First Efficient and Exemplary Cause, and the Ultimate Final Cause.⁵

¹We call it *philosophical* anthropology to distinguish it from *cultural* anthropology, which is empirical, rather than philosophical, in nature.

²As Aristotle states in *Metaphysics*, "There is a science which studies Being *qua* Being, and the properties inherent in it in virtue of its own nature. This science is not the same as any of the so-called particular sciences, for none of the others contemplates Being generally *qua* Being; they divide off some portion of it and study the attribute of this portion, as do for example the mathematical sciences. But since it is for the first principles and the most ultimate causes that we are searching, clearly they must belong to something in virtue of its own nature" (ARISTOTLE, *Metaphysics* [henceforth cited simply as *Metaph.*], tr. by W.D. Ross, Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1924, I, I.1, 1003a21-28).

In languages, like English, that do not distinguish well between *being* in the sense of "something that exists" (in Latin: *ens*) and *being* as a synonym of "to be" (in Latin: *esse*), this definition is often translated as "being *qua* being" or "being as being." However, this rendition is rather misleading: metaphysics studies existing *things* (*entia*) insofar as they are, not primarily that perfection or attribute of existing things that we call "being" (*esse*).

³We will touch on some of these, as they regard logic, when we go over the *transcendentals* in the part of the course on the logic of the concept.

⁴Thus, God is not a mere entity, in the strict sense of the term, not a mere thing that exists: rather, He is Being Itself (Latin: *Ipsium Esse*).

⁵This pattern—that the cause is not the object of a science—is common throughout all sciences. For example, consider biology, whose object is living things as regards their bodily life. Biology links the life processes of living things to its chemical causes: for example, the chemical pathways by which organisms extract the energy in the food they eat helps to explain their diets and eating habits. Biology, as such, studies the *organisms* and their properties, not the chemical causes of those properties; however, of course it relies a lot on the findings of chemistry to understand those properties in greater depth. In a similar way, the task of metaphysics is to study created entities, not God; but knowing something about God helps the science considerably in its understanding

Aristotle called this science various names, including the “first Science,” “theology,” and “wisdom”—but not “metaphysics.” That name was given first by the compilers of Aristotle’s works located in Alexandria, Egypt, simply because they placed those treatises *after* Aristotle’s works on physics (in Greek: μετὰ τὰ φύσικα, *metà tà phýsica*). Despite the trivial origin of the name, by an accident of the Greek language, it is actually quite appropriate: μετὰ can also mean “beyond,” and it turns out that metaphysics is the only philosophical discipline that can transcend *beyond* the physical (that is, the material) world.

When metaphysical principles and findings are applied to mankind, the resulting science is *philosophical anthropology*, which could be defined as the study of man, not merely regarding this or that aspect of man, but *insofar as he is*, or *insofar as he is man*. Like other applications of metaphysics, philosophical anthropology seeks to find the properties that apply universally to its object, man, and links them to their ultimate intrinsic and extrinsic causes (that is, man’s constitutive metaphysical principles, and God as First and Ultimate extrinsic Cause.) For our purposes, it will be enough to look at some of the intrinsic causes of man—that is, some of the metaphysical principles that constitute him.

1.2 Entities (*Entia*), Substances, and Accidents.

The first notion that we will introduce is *ens* (or its plural in Latin *entia*), which is the term that classical and Medieval philosophers used to translate Aristotle’s τὸ ὄν, the present participle of the Greek verb εἶναι (“to be”). In English, we will be translating *ens* as “entity.” As we discussed above, an entity is simply something that is, or (in modern parlance) exists⁶: as Aquinas puts it, *id quod est*, “that which is.” Aquinas actually employs an even more precise description: *id quod habet esse* (“that which has being”), which emphasizes the fact that the term “being” (*esse*) refers to a perfection of the entity in question—a reality that is constitutive of that entity—not a mere logical fact.

It should be evident that, outside of God, who is a special case (He is not an entity exactly, but is best characterized as Being Itself, *Ipsum Esse*), anything that is at all, in any way, is an entity. That is, there are nothing but entities—anything else, simply is not (does not exist). But what counts as an *ens*? Let’s suppose that there is an oak tree growing in the back yard. Since the oak tree clearly *is*, no one can doubt that it is an entity (*ens*). However, the oak tree does not merely “be,” as if being could occur in isolation; it has *attributes* and properties. For example, it has a height, a width, a weight, a place, textures, colors, a time, and a configuration (among many, many others). Are these attributes themselves entities (*entia*)? The answer is not as obvious, since these attributes are so closely linked to their substrate, or underlying subject, the oak tree. Nevertheless, we can resolve the issue the way Aristotle did: since each attribute can be predicated of the oak tree using the verb *to be*, it is a sign that we intuitively grasp that these attributes enjoy a certain type of being. The height of the tree, for example, certainly exists (more precisely, it *is*), for if there *were* no height, it would be a very strange tree indeed. On the other hand, the attributes of the tree hardly enjoy the same kind or degree of entities.

⁶In metaphysics, there is actually a difference in meaning between *existence* (Latin: *exsistentia*; in later Latin *existentia*, literally “a coming forth”) and *being* (*esse*). Aristotle uses the terms τὸ ὑπάρχειν (*to hypárchein*) and τὸ εἶναι (*to eînai*) to render the same idea. *Existence* is the mere fact that something is, whereas *being* refers to the ontological perfection that renders existence possible. Although in modern parlance, the terms have come to be practically interchangeable, in Aristotle and St. Thomas Aquinas, they maintain their distinct meaning. Thus, as in most cases I am referring to being as a perfection, I will try to use the verb *to be* as much as possible when referring to entities.

of being as the tree itself. The oak tree is independent, it is “by itself” and “on its own”—or as we say in metaphysical terminology, it *subsists*. In contrast, the attributes do not exist “on their own”—it would be absurd to think of height, color, weight, or any of the examples given above, without some material body to which they correspond—but rather they are always “in” another entity, or as we say, they *inhere* or are *inherent* in another entity.

By this reasoning, we have discovered the first and easiest division of entities: some entities, which we will call *substances* (Greek: οὐσία) are *subsistent*, that is, they exist by themselves. Others, which we will call *accidents* (Greek: τὰ συμβεβηκότος,⁷ *ta symbebekótos*, literally, “things that have walked alongside”) are mere attributes or modifications of a substance—as we say, they are merely *inherent* in a substance. Although substance and accident can, in a sense, be thought of logically as the different “types” of entities, they are best thought of as constituent principles of a thing: the oak tree has an intrinsic principle that makes it an oak tree—the substance, or, in this context, more often referred to as the *essence*—and a set of distinct principles, also intrinsic, that give the tree its various perfections, such as height, weight, location, and the like.

At this point, it is appropriate to make a note about the term *substance* (Latin: *substantia*), which can take on slightly different, but closely related meanings depending on the context. At the beginning, when we distinguished substance and accident as different kinds of *entia*, we were considering substances as fully constituted wholes: for instance, an oak tree, including all of its perfections or attributes. Medieval philosophers sometimes used the term “supposit” (Latin: *suppositum*, Greek: ὑπόστασις, *hypóstasis*) to denote this meaning of the term *substance*. As we just saw, however, *substance* can also be thought of as an intrinsic constitutive principle that is composed with the accidents; Western European philosophers have generally used the term *essence* (Latin: *essentia*) to denote this usage. The two meanings are so closely related that Aristotle uses the very same word, οὐσία, for both.

Regardless of how we are using the term *substance*—either as supposit or as essence—it is always the answer to the question “What is it?” Only substances subsist, and thus, only they constitute a full answer to this question. As Aristotle clarifies, unlike the accidents, only substance constitutes what a thing is simply *because* it is (τὸ τὶ ἦν εἶναι, *to ti ên êinai*)—not because of some perfection or attribute.

In sum: all created realities (which includes everything with which we have habitual contact) are rightly called *entia* or entities, because they *are*. Substances are the only entities to *subsist*, or be “by themselves,” and thus they are entities par excellence. Substances are constituted by an intrinsic principle, called the *essence*, that gives each substance its definition (that is, the essence makes that substance what it is), and the essence is composed with various perfections or attributes called *accidents*. Entities are always real; anything that lacks being entirely is *not* properly called an entity. (This idea will become important below, when we talk about *entia rationis*.)

2 The Intrinsic Composition of Man: Faculties, *Habitus*, and Operations

For the moment, that is enough of an introduction to intrinsic metaphysical principles to begin to apply them to our subject of interest, which is man—who is the only creature that makes

⁷Readers familiar with classical Greek will note that Aristotle’s term is derived from the preposition σύν (“with”), used as a prefix, and the verb βαίνο “to step or walk”—hence the verb συμβαίνο “to walk alongside.” The form τὰ συμβεβηκότος is the perfect participle.

use of logic: the sub-human creatures are incapable of it, and angels do not need it. A human being is, like our oak tree, evidently something that *subsists*: a substance. And therefore, like any substance, he is composed of an *essence* (an ontological principle that makes him who he is) and various *accidents*, which are his perfections. His essence is itself composed of ontological principles that Aristotle calls *prime matter* and *substantial form*—in man, we know these as the *body* and the *soul*—a topic that you will study at length in cosmology (the philosophy of nature) and metaphysics.

For the purposes of our discussion about logic, it is sufficient to examine certain types of perfections: faculties, *habitus*, and operations.